

Phase Retrospective

Template, Assessment Protocol & Decision Framework · v1.0 · May 2026

1 · What This Artifact Is

The Phase Retrospective is a macro-level structured assessment that fires when a phase's project list is exhausted — either the original list or an extended list added during individual project retrospectives. It evaluates the phase as a complete unit: did the projects deliver their intended growth, does the accumulated competency hold up against real-world standards, and is the system calibrated correctly for what comes next.

This is distinct from the individual project retrospective, which fires at project close and evaluates a single project in isolation. The Phase Retro threads all individual project assessments together into a phase-level verdict. It can extend the phase by adding projects if the verdict finds the competency goals unmet. It fires again after any extensions are complete and repeats until the phase is genuinely closed.

The Phase Retro produces two outputs: the completed assessment PDF (this template, filled in) and a locked forward decision recorded in both this document and in PMD_DECISION_LOG.md under Roadmap & Sequencing.

2 · Trigger, Cycle, and Self-Correction Loop

Event	Action	Output
Final project in phase list closes its individual retro	Phase Retrospective triggers. Runs full seven-section assessment.	Phase Retro PDF + locked decision
Phase Retro verdict: competency goals met	Phase closes. Portfolio Readiness Assessment fires if a Portfolio Project is next. Otherwise proceed to next phase kickoff.	Phase closed. Decision logged.
Phase Retro verdict: competency goals not fully met	Additional projects added to phase list with documented rationale. Projects run their individual nine-phase cycle and individual retros normally.	Extended project list. Decision logged.
Extended project list exhausted	Phase Retrospective fires again. Full assessment repeated.	New Phase Retro PDF. Supersedes prior version.
Repeat until phase competency goals achieved	No upper limit on iterations. The phase closes when it is ready, not on a schedule.	Final Phase Retro PDF. Phase officially closed.

3 · Seven-Section Assessment — In Sequence

The Phase Retro runs seven sections in order. Sections 1 through 5 are backward-looking — they assess what happened. Section 6 is calibration — it assesses how the system performed. Section 7 is forward-looking — it

ends in a locked decision. No section is skipped.

3.1 · Individual Project Assessment — One per Project

Before any phase-level verdict is rendered, each project in the phase is assessed individually. This surfaces which projects delivered their intended growth and which fell short before those findings are aggregated into the phase verdict. A phase that looks adequate overall can hide one project that was too easy, one that stalled, or one that was never properly closed.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
Did this project deliver the growth it was designed for within the phase's goals?	A specific yes or no with supporting evidence — not a general impression. Reference the project's North Star Document and what it committed to develop.
Which skills and tools moved materially during this project? Which did not move as expected?	Cross-referenced against Skills Tracker (Artifact #21). Gray-to-amber and amber-to-green transitions noted explicitly.
What does the individual project retro flag as incomplete or insufficient?	Direct pull from the project's retro artifact. Nothing is re-litigated here — the project retro's findings are taken as input, not re-evaluated.
Overall project verdict within this phase: Delivered · Partial · Fell Short	One of three verdicts. Partial and Fell Short verdicts feed directly into the phase-level competency assessment in Section 3.3.

3.2 · Phase Bridge Assessment — Did This Phase Follow Logically from the Last?

This section looks backward at the transition into the phase just completed. It is not evaluated at the start of a phase — only in retrospect, when the full experience of the phase is available.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
Did this phase feel like a logical next growth step after completing the previous phase?	A narrative response. Not a rating. The user describes whether the phase felt appropriately sequenced or whether something was missing at entry.
If the transition felt rough or underprepared — what was missing? What should have existed between the previous phase and this one?	Specific identification of the gap. This feeds directly into the forward-look conversation in Section 3.6 — a rough transition out is evidence for a bridging project before the next phase.
Did any project within this phase feel premature — attempted before the prerequisite skills were sufficiently developed?	If yes, which project and which skills. This is system-level feedback on phase sequencing, not personal criticism.

3.3 · Competency Assessment — Interview and Workplace Demonstrability

This is the hardest section to answer honestly and the most important one. The question is not 'do I feel confident' — it is 'could I demonstrate this competency in a job interview or deliver it under workplace expectations.' Those

are materially different bars.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
For each of this phase's stated competency goals: can you demonstrate it in a structured interview question or apply it under real workplace pressure?	Assessed per competency goal, not as a phase-wide impression. Each goal gets an explicit verdict: Demonstrable · Developing · Insufficient.
Which competencies feel genuinely owned versus competencies that feel performed or surface-level?	Honest self-identification of the difference between knowledge and capability. Knowing what a PRD is and being able to write one under pressure are different things.
Which projects produced the clearest competency gains? Which produced the least?	Threads back to the individual project assessments in Section 3.1. The projects that produced the least are the first candidates for additional work if the phase needs extension.
Overall competency verdict for this phase: Achieved · Partially Achieved · Insufficient	One of three verdicts. Insufficient triggers phase extension. Partially Achieved may trigger a targeted bridging project rather than full extension.

3.4 · Skills Tracker Cross-Reference

The competency assessment in Section 3.3 is a self-reported impression. This section grounds it in documented evidence from the Skills Tracker (Artifact #21). The two should broadly align. Where they diverge, the divergence is the finding.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
Which skills moved from gray to amber during this phase?	List explicitly. These are skills that were introduced and partially developed.
Which skills moved from amber to green?	List explicitly. These are skills that reached functional competency.
Which skills were expected to move but did not?	The gap between expected and actual movement is the primary input for phase extension decisions. A skill that should be green but remains gray is a structural gap, not a minor shortcoming.
Does the Skills Tracker evidence support or contradict the competency verdict from Section 3.3?	If self-assessment says Achieved but the tracker shows expected skills still gray, the tracker is the more reliable signal. The coach flags the contradiction explicitly.

3.5 · Confidence Score Trajectory

This section pulls the confidence scores from all projects completed within this phase from the Sentiment Diary (Artifact #23) and reads the arc. A rising arc with honest scores is the expected pattern. A flat or declining arc during a phase is a signal that something structural is wrong.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
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What was the confidence score at the start of this phase (end of previous phase score) and at the end (final project score)?	The delta. A phase should produce measurable confidence growth. A zero or negative delta requires a narrative explanation.
Did the confidence score trajectory within the phase follow a logical arc — possible early dip as complexity increased, then recovery and growth?	An early dip is normal and expected. A sustained decline or a score that never recovers by phase close is the concerning pattern.
Where the Sentiment Diary's emotional narrative and the confidence scores diverge from each other — what is the reconciling explanation?	Scores and narrative sometimes tell different stories. A high score with a predominantly negative emotional narrative may indicate score inflation. A low score with a positive narrative may indicate overcalibrated self-criticism. Both are worth naming explicitly.

3.6 · Coaching Calibration Review

The coaching mode escalates project by project on a defined schedule. This section is the mechanism that allows the schedule to self-correct. A coaching mode that is too easy produces no growth. A coaching mode that is too demanding before the foundation exists produces anxiety and stall. Neither serves the system.

Assessment prompt	What the coach is looking for
Was the coaching mode during this phase — [current mode] — appropriate, too easy, or too demanding?	A specific assessment with a supporting description. Not a general impression. Which sessions or artifacts felt appropriately challenged? Which felt under- or over-pressured?
Did the draft-first protocol (active from P1) produce better artifact quality than coach-led generation would have? Or did it feel like an obstacle?	An honest answer here. If draft-first is producing friction without corresponding quality gain, the protocol may need adjustment — not the user.
Should the coaching mode for the next phase proceed as scheduled, hold at the current level, or — in rare cases — step back?	A recommended calibration adjustment if warranted. This feeds into the forward decision in Section 3.7. Most phases will proceed as scheduled.

3.7 · Forward Look — Conversation and Locked Decision

This section ends with a locked decision. The conversation that precedes it is the mechanism — a structured dialogue about what is planned next and whether that plan still makes sense given everything surfaced in Sections 3.1 through 3.6.

The user does not need to assess whether the next phase is appropriate in the abstract — that is the system's job. The user's contribution is to describe how they feel about the transition: what they are eager to get to, what feels unfinished, what they wish they had more time with. The coach translates that into a recommendation. The locked decision reflects both.

Conversation prompt	Purpose
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The coach describes the next phase — its subject matter, its projects, its intended competency outcomes — and explains why it follows this phase in the roadmap sequence.	Ensures the user understands what is coming and why before responding. Not a test. An orientation.
Given everything in this retro — does the transition to the next phase feel right? What feels unfinished from this phase? What are you eager to get to? What would you want to spend more time with before moving on?	The user's honest response. No wrong answers. The coach uses this to calibrate the locked decision — not to override it with a predetermined plan.
Are there specific skills, tools, or concepts from this phase that feel insufficiently developed to carry forward confidently?	If yes, these become the scope of any bridging project. Specific is better than general. 'I need more PRD practice' is actionable. 'I don't feel ready' is not.

Locked Decision — Three Options:

Decision	Meaning	Documentation required
Proceed as planned	Phase closes. Next phase begins with the next scheduled project and coaching mode.	Recorded in this retro PDF (Section 3.7) and in PMD_DECISION_LOG.md under ROAD-XXX. Cross-reference between both documents.
Insert bridging project	One or more targeted projects added before the next phase begins. Scope is specific to the identified gap — not a full phase repeat.	Bridging project scope documented here. Decision logged in PMD_DECISION_LOG.md under ROAD-XXX with rationale and gap identified.
Revise phase sequence	The order of upcoming phases in the roadmap is changed. Requires explicit rationale. This is a system-level change, not a project-level one.	Revised sequence documented here. Decision logged in PMD_DECISION_LOG.md under ROAD-XXX. Roadmap artifact updated to v-next.

4 · Output Format — What Gets Produced

Output	Format	Contents	Filed to
Phase Retro PDF	PDF	Completed seven-section assessment. All verdicts, narratives, and the locked decision including its Decision Log cross-reference ID.	docs/current/ — versioned filename
Decision Log entry	PMD_DECISION_LOG.md	Locked forward decision with rationale. Cross-references this retro PDF by filename.	Repo root — appended to ROAD section

Skills Tracker update	Artifact #21 — React component	Any skill status changes confirmed during this retro are applied to the tracker.	Updated in place
Sentiment Diary update	PMD_Sentiment_Data.json	If the confidence score trajectory revealed a scoring correction needed, update the relevant project entry with a retro_note field.	Updated in place

5 · Phase Extension Protocol

When a Phase Retro verdict triggers phase extension, the extension is not a penalty — it is the system working correctly. A phase that closes before its competency goals are met produces a compounding gap that every subsequent phase inherits. Extension is cheaper than carrying forward an unresolved deficit.

Step	Action	Who
1	Identify the specific competency gap or skill deficit from the retro assessment. Name it precisely — vague extensions produce vague projects.	Coach + User
2	Scope the extension: one targeted project with a specific learning goal, or multiple projects if the gap spans several competency areas. Run the Kickoff Protocol (Artifact #20) for each extension project.	Coach
3	Extension projects run the full nine-phase cycle. Their individual retros apply normally. No shortcuts because the project is an extension.	User + Coach
4	When extension projects are complete, Phase Retro fires again. Full seven-section assessment. A new PDF is produced — it supersedes the prior version but the prior version is moved to docs/archive/, never deleted.	Coach triggers
5	Repeat until phase competency goals are achieved and the retro verdict is Proceed as planned or a Bridging Project into the next phase.	System self-corrects

6 · Locked Decisions

Decision	Detail
Retro fires at project list exhaustion	Not at a fixed project count or calendar date. The phase closes when the project list is exhausted and the retro confirms competency goals are met.
Individual project assessment before phase verdict	Each project in the phase is assessed individually before the phase-level verdict is rendered. Aggregation without individual assessment hides the projects that fell short.
Competency standard is demonstrability	Not confidence. Not familiarity. The test is: could this be demonstrated in an interview or applied under workplace expectations. That is the external anchor.

Skills Tracker cross-reference is mandatory	The tracker provides documented evidence that either supports or contradicts the self-assessed competency verdict. Where they diverge, the tracker is the more reliable signal.
Coaching calibration can adjust in both directions	The coaching mode can hold or step back as well as advance. The schedule is a default, not a mandate. The retro is the correction mechanism.
Forward look ends in a locked decision	Three options only: proceed, bridge, or revise sequence. The conversation informs the decision but does not replace it. A retro that ends without a locked decision is incomplete.
Decision recorded in both retro PDF and Decision Log	The retro PDF provides context. PMD_DECISION_LOG.md is the authoritative system record. Both are updated. Both cross-reference each other by document ID.
Prior retro versions archived, never deleted	When a phase retro is superseded by an extension retro, the prior version moves to docs/archive/. The history of how the phase evolved is part of the record.
P() helper — all table cells	Per locked PDF pattern. All table cell content wrapped in Paragraph. VALIGN TOP. Never plain strings.

Version History

Version	Key change	Date
v1.0	Initial spec — trigger and self-correction loop, seven-section assessment protocol (individual project assessment, phase bridge, competency check, skills tracker cross-reference, confidence score trajectory, coaching calibration review, forward look with locked decision), phase extension protocol, output format, dual Decision Log cross-referencing.	May 2026